

Azam Khan
Senior SP leader

actress Jaya Bachchan for the Rajya Sabha election. She accused the senior ally of ignoring its PDA—*pichhda* (backward), Dalit, *alpsankhyak* (minority)—base. Pallavi, who had won the 2022 assembly election on the SP symbol, was keen to contest the Lok Sabha poll under the I.N.D.I.A. flag. For a while, things seemed on track. After the snub, Pallavi on March 31 announced her party's alliance with the Asaduddin Owaisi-led All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (AIMIM) in UP. In short, an alliance on the rebound, conceived out of pique, to cut into the I.N.D.I.A. bloc votes.

in Rampur, where ignoring Azam's wishes yet again, Akhilesh fielded a Delhi-based imam, Mohibullah Nadvi. No one was left in doubt that a ping-pong battle was going on when another Azam campwallah, Asim Raza, threw his Karakul hat into the ring, though his papers got cancelled later.

THE BJP SNUB

In the BJP, meanwhile, there were quite a few sitting MPs, or at least their supporters, in for a rude shock. Among the rejects were big names like Union minister of state and former army chief V.K. Singh (Ghaziabad), Gandhi family scion Varun (Pilibhit) and former minister Santosh Gangwar (Bareilly).

SOURCES IN THE SP CLAIM THAT AKHILESH YADAV IS NOT READY TO YIELD TO 'PRESSURE TACTICS' BY ANY SMALLER PARTY AFTER THE RLD'S EXIT



The sour vibes are not just at the inter-party level—even within the SP, the *raita* has been spilling a bit between Akhilesh and old vanguard Azam Khan, which led to confusion and embarrassment for the SP in finalising candidates for Moradabad and Rampur. Azam, currently lodged in jail, had apparently asked Akhilesh to fight from Rampur—a constituency Azam had made synonymous with himself. He also wanted sitting MP S.T. Hasan dropped from Moradabad next door. But the SP chief chose to repose faith in Hasan. On the last day for nominations, March 27, Azam's close confidante Ruchi Vira sprang a surprise by claiming to be the party candidate. Hasan had no option but to withdraw. More drama unfolded

After the BJP's apparent snub to V.K. Singh, several outfits from his Thakur community called the move unfair—even though the two-time MP had recused himself hours before sitting Ghaziabad MLA Atul Garg was named in his stead. Garg has been facing resentment in his constituency, with instances of him being hooted out of meetings at housing societies surfacing lately.

Varun, on the other hand, had been in the doghouse since he became vocal on issues like unemployment, inflation and poverty. The BJP retained his mother, Maneka Gandhi, from Sultanpur, but tossed Pilibhit to Congress import Jitin Prasada, now a minister in the Yogi cabinet. The SP candidate, Bhagwat Saran Gangwar, claims irate Varun supporters have sworn fealty to him. *Raita* is indeed a fluid substance. ■

OF RANIS AND ALSO-RANS

A royal family member dons saffron robes to dip her toes in politics, and invites the TMC's censure

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

Rani ma, Rajmata... It's with these loaded honorifics, thick with the flavour of nostalgia for a feudal past, that the BJP has been addressing Amrita Roy—matriarch of the former royal family of Krishnanagar and the party's candidate for the eponymous Lok Sabha constituency. That wasn't going to pass without comment in Bengal, with its legacy of decades of subaltern politics having moved seamlessly from the Left to Trinamool Congress chief Mamata Banerjee. The chief minister, for whom a self-styling as one of the hoi polloi is core to her political image, took no time to issue admonitions to the saffron camp—that phrases like 'queen mother' had no place in a democratic lexicon. "They are calling her Rajmata.... In our country, all of us are subjects and there is no king. Whoever is a king can go and live in the royal palace," she said, waxing acerbic at a rally in Dhubulia, in Krishnanagar constituency, on March 31. Mahua Moitra, her party's candidate, too, let the artillery fly.

Roy, who had hitherto betrayed no political streak, was inducted into the BJP on March 20 in the presence of leader of the Opposition Suvendu Adhikari. Days later, she featured in the BJP's fifth list of candidates—joining a modest band of ex-royals who had dabbled in Bengal's politics. Even when they did so, their kingly aura never amounted to much, unlike in states still steeped in a feudal culture,